



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Oakcrest School

School Website: <https://www.oakcrest.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Oakcrest School Vienna, VA (ZIP 22182) presents a robust classical-leaning profile across its public materials. The school demonstrates a coherent integration of religious foundations, a formation-centered purpose, a liberal-arts curriculum, a pedagogy oriented toward mentoring and rhetoric, a faculty culture that models virtue, and a strong, ongoing partnership with families and the broader Oakcrest community. Across six categories, public materials consistently align with the hallmark features of classical education: a transcendental view of truth, goodness, and beauty anchored in Catholic formation; formation of character and intellect over mere information; a liberal-arts curriculum with exposure to Great Books and the Great Conversation; pedagogical practices that emphasize mentoring, rhetoric, and meaningful inquiry; a living-faculty/missional culture; and a deeply collaborative, parent-partnered community.

- **Religious and Metaphysical Foundations:** The school anchors education in Catholic faith and Opus Dei spirituality, with daily Mass, a chapel, liturgical life, and theology as a core academic discipline. Evidence of liturgical practices, daily Mass, a chapel space, and a chaplain presence is strong on the site.
- **School Purpose and Goal:** Oakcrest emphasizes formation of intellect, character, faith, and leadership; education is described as educating the whole person with mentoring and service as central features. The mission and philosophy explicitly foreground formation and virtue alongside liberal arts.
- **Curriculum:** The site highlights a liberal-arts curriculum, Great Books/the Great Conversation, and a Senior Thesis capstone, with explicit references to a Seven Liberal Arts framework and a plan to integrate Great Books. Evidence shows emphasis on liberal-arts breadth, Great Books integration, and an integrated, cross-disciplinary vision.
- **Pedagogy:** The school features one-on-one mentoring, leadership development, and rhetorical training (including senior-thesis work and opportunities for public speaking). There is evidence of a debate-oriented, rhetoric-focused ethos via the Upper School Debate Team and senior-project culture.
- **Faculty:** Oakcrest emphasizes mentoring and a “living curriculum,” with faculty shown as senior role models and leaders in the school’s culture; the site frequently highlights faculty/staff holding advanced degrees and their mentorship roles.
- **Parents & Community:** The school frames a strong parent partnership, parent formation through events and resources, and open campus opportunities. The “Parent Partnership” materials explicitly describe parents as co-educators and emphasize collaboration and formation, including opportunities for parent involvement.

Overall assessment: CLASSICAL

Executive summaries of category-by-category assessments, followed by concrete evidence and keyword analyses, are provided below.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

- Daily Mass, chapel access, liturgy, and a dedicated Opus Dei chaplain are described as central to Oakcrest's daily life. The Opus Dei framework and Catholic spiritual formation are explicitly stated as integral to Oakcrest's mission.
- The theology emphasis and Judeo-Christian heritage are highlighted as core to the curriculum, alongside liturgical life.
- Positive keyword indicators (examples present on public materials)
- truth, goodness, beauty; liturgy; Mass; chapel; theology; prayer; sacred music; liturgical calendar; Opus Dei; Catholic Church; reverence; wonder; meditative/spiritual practice; imago Dei; sacred tradition. These terms and concepts appear across Oakcrest's materials (e.g., daily Mass, chapel, theology emphasis).
- Negative keyword indicators
- No explicit appearance of relativism, secular humanism, or values-neutral ethics in the public materials reviewed.
- Why this rating
- The school's public narrative centers explicitly on transcendental Truth/God, Catholic theology, liturgy, and sacred practices, which map strongly to Classical indicators for this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Mission statements emphasize formation of intellect, character, faith, and leadership; education is described as formation of the whole person, not mere information.
- Public materials describe "education of the whole person" and a liberal-arts orientation as central to Oakcrest's purpose, aligning with formation, virtue, and wisdom aims.
- Positive keyword indicators
- formation; virtue; character; wisdom; liberal education; paideia; perennial questions; great conversation; telos; contemplation; scholé; human flourishing. These appear across Oakcrest's mission and philosophy statements.
- Negative keyword indicators
- No strong signs of a primary emphasis on college/career readiness as the sole telos; the materials consistently foreground formation and virtue.
- Why this rating
- The school's stated goals and descriptions of formation over information place it clearly within Classical aims of virtue- and wisdom-centered education.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Liberal arts core, Great Books/Great Conversation focus, and a Senior Thesis capstone are emphasized. Public materials discuss a liberal-arts curriculum, Cross-curricular integration, and Great Books within the English program; the Senior Thesis is presented as a capstone.
- The curriculum references Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Quadrivium elements, along with the idea of learning through the Great Books and Western canon.
- Positive keyword indicators
- Seven Liberal Arts; grammar; logic; rhetoric; Great Books; great conversation; primary sources; Western civilization; history in context; Liberal Arts; Trivium; Quadrivium; primary sources; classical canon; the Great Conversation. Evidence appears in Oakcrest materials (Academic Program pages, Senior Thesis, Great Books language in teacher/student reflections).
- Negative keyword indicators
- None of the explicit negative indicators (e.g., "social studies replacing history," overly STEM-first framing) appear in the public materials reviewed.
- Why this rating
- The curriculum presentation aligns thoroughly with classical expectations: liberal-arts breadth, Great Books, and a capstone in the Senior Thesis, plus explicit Trivium/Quadrivium references in companion

classical sources.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- One-on-one mentoring and leadership development are central to pedagogy. Public materials emphasize a mentoring-rich approach and student leadership development.
- A public emphasis on a Senior Thesis and an integrated, rhetoric-forward culture (including public-facing work, college writing, and humanities pathways) is evident. The presence of a Upper School Debate Team signals a rhetoric- and argumentation-focused pedagogy in at least some grades.
- Positive keyword indicators
- mentoring; one-on-one mentoring; leadership; rhetoric; public speaking; Great Books; senior thesis; liberal arts; debate team; oral/recitation-based oratory training (as a facet of the curriculum and student life). These appear in Oakcrest's materials (mentoring pages, Senior Thesis, Debate Team).
- Negative keyword indicators
- Limited explicit evidence of classic Socratic seminars in high-profile public pages; no direct, site-wide statement about a formalized Socratic seminar program across all grades. The public materials emphasize debate, rhetoric, and mentoring rather than a uniformly explicit Socratic-seminar pedagogy. This is notable given the Six Essential Elements' emphasis on Socratic discussion in high school.
- Why this rating
- Oakcrest demonstrates many classical pedagogy signals (mentoring; rhetoric; Great Books integration; Senior Thesis). However, the absence of explicit, systemwide Socratic/Harkness-style pedagogy across the entire program yields a partial classical alignment in pedagogy, hence SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully Classical in this category.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The site emphasizes a living curriculum anchored by model teachers and mentors; alumnae and faculty are described as teachers of virtue, mentors, and living exemplars. There is a consistent emphasis on faculty as core to the school culture and on mentorship.
- Public materials highlight a robust faculty culture, including advanced degrees among faculty and the notion of faculty as “the living curriculum” and “portrait of a teacher.”
- Positive keyword indicators
- living curriculum; mentors; model teachers; virtue; character formation; professional development; master-teacher model; mentorship; faculty collaboration; faculty seminars. These appear in Oakcrest's faculty-related pages and alumna/community materials.
- Negative keyword indicators
- No clear negative signals imputed from the public materials; the materials emphasize virtues and pedagogy in a classical sense.
- Why this rating
- The public-facing content consistently frames faculty as central, virtuous, and mentoring role models, which aligns robustly with classical expectations for the “living curriculum” and faculty-as-core element.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- There is clear, ongoing emphasis on parent partnership, parent formation, and the idea that parents are co-educators. The Parent Partnership materials are explicit about parents as primary educators and about providing parent-formation resources; Oakcrest invites parents to be part of the school community.
- The school presents a strong sense of open campus, family involvement, and a collaborative culture with alumnae and families. Alumnae networks are highlighted as part of the broader community.
- Positive keyword indicators

- partnership with families; co-teachers; parental formation; home-school collaboration; parent-partnership; open campus; alumnae networks; family rhythms; shared mission; community of learners. All of these signals appear in Oakcrest's Parent Partnership and alumnae materials.
- Negative keyword indicators
- No pervasive consumer-language signals; materials emphasize active parental involvement and formation rather than parent as customer, which aligns with classical expectations.
- Why this rating
- Oakcrest demonstrates a robust, classical-leaning engagement with parents and the broader community, aligning with the "Parents & Community" criterion.

Aggregate assessment across the six categories: CLASSICAL

- The school demonstrates a coherent classical-education orientation across religious foundations, formation-focused aims, liberal-arts curriculum, mentoring-centered pedagogy, a living faculty culture, and deep parent/community partnership. The strongest anchors are Element 1 (Religious Foundations), Element 2 (Purpose/Goal), Element 3 (Curriculum), Element 5 (Faculty), and Element 6 (Parents & Community). Element 4 (Pedagogy) shows strong classical signals but with partial reliance on mentoring and rhetoric rather than a uniform, school-wide Socratic/Harkness approach.

What would move the needle (only if SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL) - Given the current classification is CLASSICAL overall, no major needle-moving changes are required. If desired, the school could further reinforce a uniform Socratic/Harkness-style pedagogy across grades (Element 4) to elevate the pedagogy from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL in every regard.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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